# World I Cannot Touch

## By Janet O'Neill

I have to confess. I watch people. I scout out my favorite spots: the food court at the mall, amusement parks, ball games. I watch people and write the rest of their stories. I have regulars. There's Mr. Tight Pants. Is he going to get Sbarro pizza or Panda Wok today? Then it's salad and I make up the rest of the story that Mr. Tight Pants has a big date tonight with someone who he's wanted to date for a long time, but he's not sure if it is a date or just a casual meeting, so Mr. Tight Pants figures eating some salad increases his chances of becoming Mr. Not-SoTight Pants, which will simultaneously increase his chances of it being a date.

You know - stuff like that.

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## INTRODUCTION

*In today's world, even as awareness and tolerance increase, homosexuality continues to be viewed negatively and through stereotypes. Unfortunately, many of us are treated unfairly throughout society - in church, at school and even in our own homes. At various times homosexuality has been considered a crime, a sickness, a sin or at the very least an abnormality. Given these negative social, religious and familial attitudes it is likely that most gay and lesbian people face difficult and challenging experiences on a regular basis. Ostracized by their peers and rejected by adults, gay and lesbian teens develop disturbing thoughts and feelings about their place in this . . . World I Cannot Touch by Janet O'Neill*

I meet this girl, Andy (short for Andrea), at the movie theater. I write the rest of her story. For the first time ever, I include myself in the story.

OK - more admissions. I watch movies more than once.

OK - sometimes double-digits. It was during my sixth screening of Bed of Roses, that Andy came into the theatre. I always like to get there early. That way I have more time to concoct stories about the others. I'd seen her before. She'd come alone just like I would and she always brought her own food. Economical. Mental

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note to guess she's not very wealthy. Add that to the story.

I love to spy on people in cars. People make the false assumption that they are alone. Don't look directly at them or they'll give you this bug-eye stare. Wear sunglasses. Use the rear-view mirror. Suddenly, a whole new world opens up. A business woman picks her nose. Manicured nails. Football players singing musical tunes. OK - that never happened. Another case of me making up the end of the story.

Bed of Roses closed quickly, and I find myself feigning interest in other films. After enduring Celtic Pride, I find Andy sitting in a crowded theater before The Truth About Cats and Dogs. OK, let's be honest, the theater wasn't that crowded, but I acted like it was and sat next to her. Hey, I remember you Bed of Roses, right?

Her first words. More details to add to the story.

Suddenly, I've got the whole story written. Oddly, it's got sexual tension. I'd only had two

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boyfriends, both of which agreed that it was alright to wait. I was fine with waiting for years. But now I'm writing Andy's story, and the narrative is telling me not to wait. To do anything but wait. To go with her and . . .

We spent time doing fun things, goofy things, educational things. Our chance encounter at the movie theater had taken us to the Farmer's Market, pottery class, feng shi class, fencing lessons. And, of course, more movies. I couldn't get enough of Andy. She worked at the local bank. Guess who opened a checking and savings account and constantly had a transaction to make?

We became an official couple after she got off work one Saturday afternoon. We stopped by the fair and it was really crowded, so we held hands to stay together. I couldn't look forward anymore. I just stared at our hands...together. The next thing I knew, we were back by the lake. It started with a kiss on the neck and the intensity grew. Suddenly, we were . . .

OK, I get it. You're grossed out. You want to hear a lesbian love story as much as my mother does. She

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didn't have words for lesbians because she refused to speak about them - ever. Two lesbians could be making out three feet in front of her, and she'd only allow us to talk about what we would order for dinner. So when I had weird feelings for my ballet teacher, I didn't say much. Just waited for a guy to come along and find me.

But I understand the gross thing. I do. I mean, after watching Ellen DeGeneres and Anne Heche turn it into a farce, who could blame you? They thought they were bringing lesbianism about in the open. And they did - but put it in the open in a way that no one wanted to see. So I understand how you don't want to hear about my story. But in case you were wondering, it can be beautiful.

Time passes, memories fade and new memories begin to take their place. I wasn't possessive, but I didn't want her to leave. Ever. I didn't want to share her and sleep without her next to me. Andy was the eye-opener. If someone had told me I'd fall in love with a guy named Andy, I'd say sure, fine. If you'd said that Andy was short for Andrea, I'd do one of those Elaine

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from Seinfeld pushes: "Get out!" I no longer completed people's stories anymore. I was too engrossed in mine. Yet, despite this self-actualized state, when we'd walk hand-in-hand amidst other couples, I'd arrive at the same conclusion: This is heaven . . .for now. Did one relationship count as being a lesbian? Could I live as a lesbian permanently? How long could I last? I didn't know any of the answers. I just knew it couldn't last forever. This was not a life I could live. Look, but don't touch.

But what if I did go for it? Say hell with it all and I am who I am. I've already got hypoglycemia and this scar from a dog bite when I was four. This would be something else to explain to everyone I meet. There would be the attempts for religious conversion. The guys wanting to "fix" me. Everyone visualizing the stereotype of the hairy, gross, lesbian who must have grown up abused. I could fight the stereotypes. Explain myself. But, I'm not a strong person. Look, but don't touch, I decided. Sure, don't touch. But then there's Andy. I'd rather explain lesbianism a million times over than

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explain to her that it just won't work. After all, it did work!

I was driving to the bookstore one day, blissful yet confused, which had now become my constant state. I was stopped at a stoplight and I thought - hey, for old times sake, let's write the end of a story. The man at the newspaper stand didn't seem interesting. Suddenly, I try the old mirror trick and I see this couple really going at it. I mean...they were...WOW! Now that's love! The light turns green, and they pull away from each other. It was Andy. Andy was with some guy. Some guy. A guy. You know how sometimes, you can catch a person's eye in your rearview mirror? Andy saw me. I tromped the accelerator, but she'd seen me in the mirror, watching my eyes fill with tears.

Look, but don't touch. You touch; you get burned. Touching is going too far. I look, don't touch, and complete the rest of the story.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Janet O'Neill***
***Book: Turning Points***
***Publisher: Tichenor Publishing***
***ISBN: 978-0742117013***
***Date: 2001***

## AWARD HISTORY

***2006 National Qualifier***

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